

Product Requirements Document (PRD)

Project Name

The Observation Files

Tagline: *"Every detail tells a story. Every story hides a lie."*

Vision

Create a detective mystery web application where players solve crimes through observation, logical deduction, and interrogation rather than reflexes or action.

The game should feel inspired by:

- Detective Conan
- The Mentalist
- Ace Attorney
- Return of the Obra Dinn
- Her Story

The experience must reward intelligence, attention to detail, and reasoning.

No jump scares.

No horror.

No supernatural powers.

No random guessing.

Every solution must be logically explainable from available evidence.

Product Goal

Players become independent detectives solving unique criminal cases.

Instead of searching for hidden glowing objects, players observe details, interview suspects, compare evidence, identify contradictions, build theories, and finally accuse the correct suspect.

Every solved case should make players feel:

"I figured it out."

not

"The game told me."

Platform

Primary:

Responsive Web App

Future:

- Android
 - iOS
 - Desktop (Electron)
 - Steam
-

Art Style

Modern minimalist.

Semi-realistic UI.

Dark theme.

Flat illustrations.

Soft shadows.

Glassmorphism.

No pixel art.

No anime art.

Professional detective aesthetic.

Target Audience

Age:

15–35

Players who enjoy:

- detective stories
 - mystery novels
 - Sherlock Holmes
 - Detective Conan
 - The Mentalist
 - puzzle games
 - deduction games
 - escape rooms
-

Core Gameplay Loop

Receive Case



Read Initial Report



Visit Crime Scene



Observe Objects



Collect Evidence



Interview Witnesses



Interview Suspects



Compare Statements



Find Contradictions

↓

Build Theory Board

↓

Choose Killer

↓

Explain Logic

↓

Case Solved

↓

Unlock New Case

Gameplay Philosophy

There should never be a "click everything until something happens."

Players should constantly think.

Observation is gameplay.

Logic is gameplay.

Dialogue is gameplay.

Core Features

1. Case Selection

Main menu displays available cases.

Initially:

Case 1

Case 2

Case 3

Later updates unlock more.

Each case displays:

Title

Difficulty

Completion %

Stars earned

Time taken

2. Crime Scene

Interactive environment.

Player can rotate around.

Zoom.

Inspect.

Click objects.

Objects contain:

Description

Photos

Fingerprints

Blood

Broken items

Hidden compartments

Documents

Footprints

Weapon

Not every object is important.

Red herrings exist.

3. Observation Mode

Main mechanic.

Instead of highlighting clues, player manually inspects.

Example:

Click:

Coffee Mug

Observations:

Half full

Still warm

Lipstick mark

Left-handed placement

No fingerprints

Each observation unlocks deductions.

4. Evidence Inventory

Collected evidence stored as cards.

Example:

Knife

Receipt

Medical Report

Phone

Wallet

Ticket

Shoes

Every card contains:

Photo

Description

Observations

Linked deductions

Related suspects

5. Character Profiles

Each suspect has profile.

Contains:

Name

Occupation

Age

Relationship

Motive

Personality

Known habits

Statements

Timeline

Evidence linked

Relationship graph

Nothing should reveal guilt directly.

6. Interrogation System

Most important mechanic.

Dialogue trees.

Players choose questions.

New evidence unlocks new dialogue.

Example:

Where were you?

↓

"I was home."

↓

Present Restaurant Receipt

↓

"Actually..."

↓

Present CCTV

↓

Lie detected.

NPC behavior changes based on pressure.

Some become nervous.

Some angry.

Some silent.

Some overexplain.

7. Contradiction Mechanic

Statements stored automatically.

Player compares.

Example:

Witness A

"I heard glass break."

Medical report:

Victim already dead.

Contradiction.

Another:

Suspect:

"I never met him."

Phone logs:

47 calls.

Contradiction.

8. Timeline Reconstruction

Player drags events.

Example

8:00 Dinner

↓

8:30 Phone Call

↓

9:05 Murder

↓

9:20 Witness Arrives

Incorrect order blocks progression.

9. Theory Board

Large detective board.

Player connects:

Evidence

People

Locations

Motive

Timeline

Relationships

Weapon

Each connection increases confidence.

Wrong connections decrease confidence.

No auto-solving.

10. Final Accusation

Player chooses:

Killer

Motive

Weapon

Method

Timeline

Supporting evidence

Final explanation.

Game scores:

Accuracy

Logic

Evidence usage

Time

Optional clues used

Observation Examples

Wallet

Observe:

Wet

No cash

Fresh scratch

Business card

Expired license

Window

Observe:

Broken outward

Glass outside

Curtain torn

Mud

Victim

Observe:

Watch stopped

Burn marks

Right-handed

Defensive wounds

Deduction Examples

Observation:

Coffee cold.

↓

Victim died earlier.

Observation:

Fresh mud.

↓

Recently outside.

Observation:

Wedding ring mark.

↓

Recently removed ring.

Observation:

Ticket unused.

↓

Suspect lied.

Case Structure

Every case contains:

Opening

Crime Scene

Evidence

Witnesses

Suspects

Twist

Hidden truth

Ending

Replay score

Difficulty Levels

Easy

Few suspects

Simple motives

Few contradictions

Medium

Hidden motives

More evidence

Multiple lies

Hard

Red herrings

Complex timeline

Indirect clues

Psychological manipulation

Expert

Multiple killers

Fake evidence

Unreliable witnesses

Hidden rooms

Scoring System

Evidence Found

Observation Accuracy

Wrong Accusations

Time

Optional Clues

Logic Bonus

Perfect Investigation Bonus

Star Rating

1-5

Hint System

Three hint levels.

Hint 1

Look closer.

Hint 2

Relevant object highlighted.

Hint 3

Logical direction suggested.

Using hints reduces score.

Save System

Automatic save.

Progress stored locally.

Future:

Cloud save.

UI Pages

Landing

Main Menu

Case Selection

Crime Scene

Investigation

Character Profiles

Evidence Inventory

Timeline

Theory Board

Interrogation

Results

Achievements

Settings

Profile

Audio

Ambient rain

Office ambience

Clock ticking

Keyboard

Camera shutter

Paper flipping

Soft piano

Minimal soundtrack

No loud music.

Animations

Smooth transitions.

Evidence cards slide.

Dialogue typing.

Board connections animate.

Minimal but polished.

Tech Stack

Frontend

React

Next.js

TypeScript

TailwindCSS

Framer Motion

React Query

Zustand

Backend

Supabase

Authentication

Supabase Auth

Storage

Supabase Storage

Database

PostgreSQL

Deployment

Vercel

Analytics

PostHog

Database Tables

users

cases

case_progress

suspects

evidence

observations

dialogues

statements

timeline_events

theories

scores

achievements

MVP Scope

Launch with:

3 handcrafted cases

12 suspects

80+ observations

40 evidence cards

Interrogation

Timeline

Theory Board

Scoring

Save System

Responsive UI

Dark Theme

Future Features

Procedurally generated cases

Daily mystery

Multiplayer detective competition

Community-created cases

AI-generated witness dialogue

Steam Workshop support

Leaderboards

Achievements

Seasonal events

Monetization

Free to play.

Premium Case Packs.

Cosmetic detective themes.

No pay-to-win.

No energy system.

No intrusive ads.

Success Metrics

Average session:

20–40 minutes

Case completion rate:

Above 70%

Replay rate:

Above 50%

Hint usage:

Below 35%

Average rating:

4.5+

Development Roadmap

Phase 1

Project setup

Authentication

UI framework

Navigation

Responsive layout

Phase 2

Crime Scene

Evidence system

Observation mechanic

Phase 3

Interrogation

Dialogue engine

Contradiction detection

Phase 4

Timeline

Theory Board

Scoring

Phase 5

Three complete cases

Audio

Animations

Polish

Phase 6

Public beta

Collect feedback

Fix balancing

Optimize performance

Launch Version 1.0

Guiding Principles

Every clue must matter.

Every lie must be discoverable.

Every accusation must be explainable.

Players should never win through luck.

The game should make players feel like a real detective—not because the detective is brilliant, but because **the player** was observant enough to uncover the truth.